

1345 Enslaved Swimmers and Divers in the Atlantic World Although Stedman, who was raised in Holland, could swim, he admitted that most Guiana slaves were much better swimmers and divers than he. While Robert Walsh was traversing Brazil in the 1820s, he concluded that most slaves could swim, dubbing them “amphibious.” Francis Fedric, who was enslaved in Virginia and Kentucky during the mid-1800s, contended that most bondpeople could swim, saying “unlike most slaves, I never learned to swim.”⁴⁴ In the American South standards of modesty probably prevented adult bondwomen from swimming. Caribbean and Latin American slaves maintained many West African customs and mores, most lived in relative isolation from whites, and the year-round heat kept the majority from wearing much clothing. Consequently, bondwomen there, like their African counterparts, probably faced little stigma when they swam nude. Stedman penned several accounts of male and female bondpeople swimming together nude without being thought immodest or immoral. Likewise, Richard Ligon detailed the swimming prowess of the nude Barbadian bondwoman who captured a duck. Even though slavery placed American bondwomen, who performed much the same work as bondmen, outside southern gender conventions, white and black society still encouraged and forced them to conform to many of those conventions. Female slaves themselves may have internalized southern mores. Thus, while enslaved female children may have disrobed to swim or play in the water, once a female slave reached puberty, black and white southerners would have viewed such actions as immodest. As bondwomen entered adolescence, they probably felt that swimming was no longer an acceptable activity.⁴⁵ In *Born in Bondage*, the historian Marie Jenkins Schwartz asserted that slaveholders did not encourage their slaves to learn to swim because they felt swimming did not increase slaves’ economic value, aided them in escaping, and might lead to drowning and the loss of valuable human property. Indeed, many slaves incorporated swimming into their repertoires of resistance. But swimming could increase a bondman’s usefulness and monetary worth, and some slaveholders encouraged it.⁴⁶

⁴⁴ Ligon, *True and Exact History of the Island of Barbadoes*, 52; Stedman, *Narrative of Five Year’s Expedition Against the Revolted Negroes of Surinam*, 7–8, 57, 86, 154, 157–58, 164, 192, 214; Robert Walsh, *Notice of Brazil in 1828 and 1829* (2 vols., Boston, 1831), I, 281; Francis Fedric, *Slave Life in Virginia and Kentucky* (London, 1863), 1–2. ⁴⁵ Gwendolyn Midlo Hall, *Social Control in Slave Plantation Societies: A Comparison of St. Domingue and Cuba* (1971; Baton Rouge, 1996), 13–17, 23–24, 152–53; Stedman, *Narrative of Five Year’s Expedition Against the Revolted Negroes of Surinam*, 7, 57, 214; Ligon, *True and Exact History of the Island of Barbadoes*, 53; Dunn, *Sugar and Slaves*, 237–38, 249, 264, 270, 283–84, 286; Elizabeth Fox-Genovese, *Within the Plantation Household: Black and White Women of the Old South* (Chapel Hill, 1988), 47, 109, 196, 202–3, 216, 222–23, 294, 296–97, 298, 440n45; Benjamin Drew, ed., *A North-Side View of Slavery. The Refugee; or, The Narratives of Fugitive Slaves in Canada* (Boston, 1856), 221; Rogers, *The House of Bondage*, 24; Kearney, *Slaveholder’s Daughter*, 37–38; Norbert Elias, *The History of Manners: The Civilizing Process* (New York, 1978), 131–33, 138, 162–63, 165, 164, esp. 187; Morgan, *Laboring Women*, 144–65; Michael Craton, *Searching for the Invisible Man: Slavery and Plantation Life in Jamaica* (Cambridge, Mass., 1978), 142–43. ⁴⁶ Schwartz, *Born in Bondage*, 101, 130. On swimming and resistance, see Hall, “Maritime Maroons,” 387–400; Chinae, “Quest for Freedom,” 51–87; Douglas Hall, ed., *Miserable Slavery: Thomas Tistlewood in Jamaica, 1750–86* (Hong Kong, 1989), 54–55; John Andrew Jackson, *The Experience of a Slave in South Carolina* (London, 1862), 23–24; James Pennington, *A Narrative of Events of the Life of J. H. Banks, an Escaped Slave, from the Cotton State, Alabama* (Liverpool, 1861), 37–41; Clinkscales, *On the Old Plantation*, 16–19; Solomon Bayley, *A Narrative of Some Remarkable Incidents in the Life of Solomon Bayley Formerly a Slave in the State of Delaware* (London, 1825), 5–7; James Lindsay Smith, *Autobiography of James L. Smith, Including, Also, Reminiscences of Slave Life* (Norwich, 1881), 16–20; David Turnbull, *Travels in the West Indies. Cuba; with Notices of Porto Rico* (London, 1840), 365; Al-